PART I · PITCH · 1

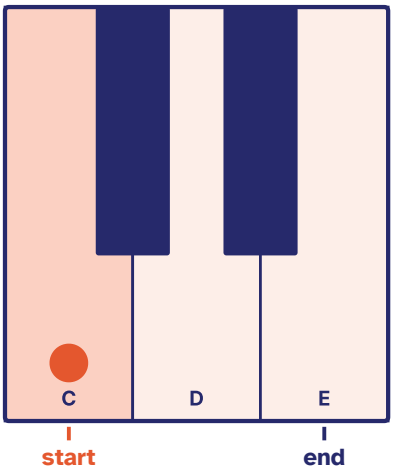
The keyboard

Eighty-eight keys look like a lot, but they repeat one small pattern again and again. Learn the pattern once and you can find any key without counting. Left is **low**, right is **high**.

THE SECRET

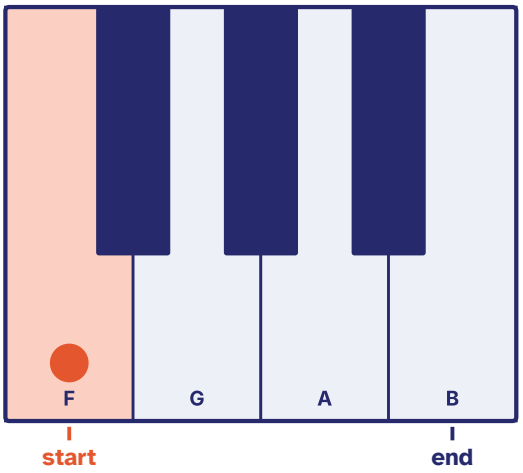
Two black keys: start on C. Three black keys: start on F. Then walk on.

2 black keys: C D E



on the piano E and F touch

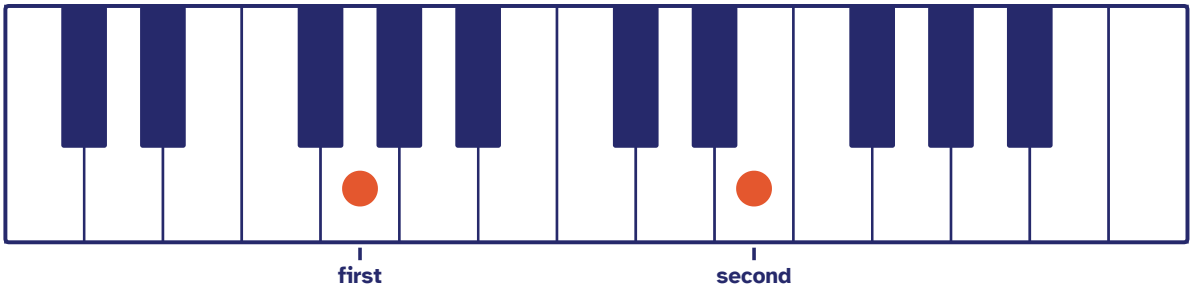
3 black keys: F G A B



Pulled apart: each family has a first key (start) and a last key (end)

EXAMPLE 1

Higher or lower?



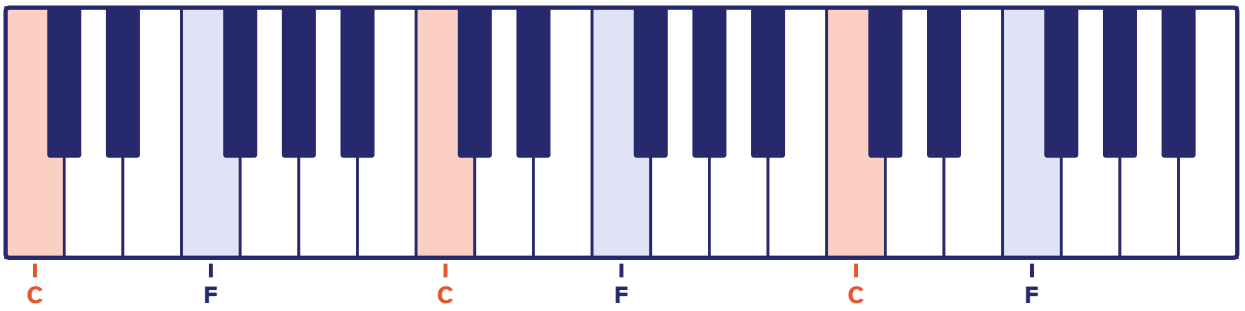
1. **Find the two red keys.**
2. **Which one is further right?**
3. **Right means higher:** play both and listen.

The second note is **higher**: it is to the right. Left is always lower, right always higher.

PART I · PITCH · 1 · CONTINUED

THE RULE

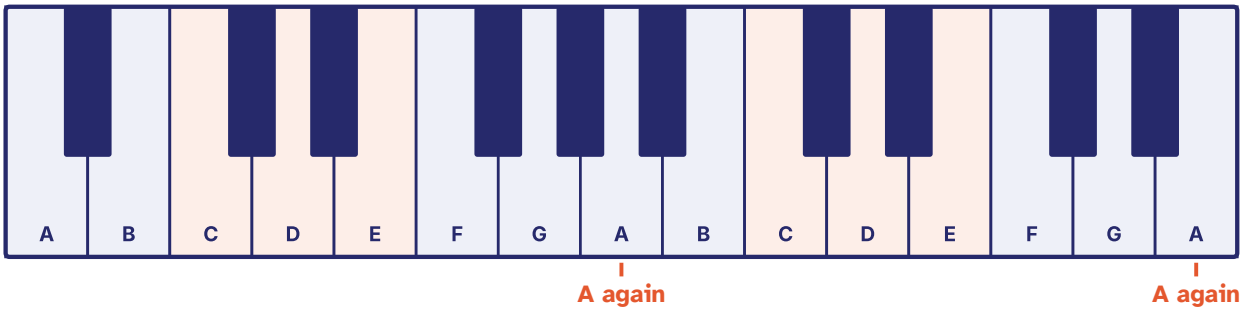
Find the group, then its first key. **Looking for D or E? Find two black keys and start on C. Looking for G, A or B? Find three black keys and start on F. You never have to count from far away.**



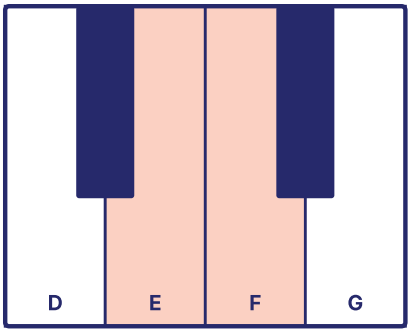
The pattern repeats all the way along: every two starts on C, every three on F

Seven letters, round and round

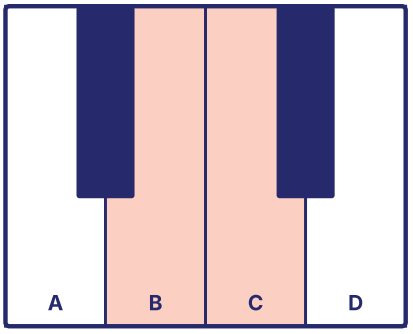
The white keys use only seven letters: **A B C D E F G**. There is no H. After G the next key is **A** again, and the seven letters go round and round, like the days of the week, all the way up the keyboard. **C D E** always sit round the two black keys, **F G A B** round the three. **E–F** and **B–C** have no black key between.



A B C D E F G, A B C D E F G, A …: after G, back to A



E–F: no black key between



B–C: no black key between

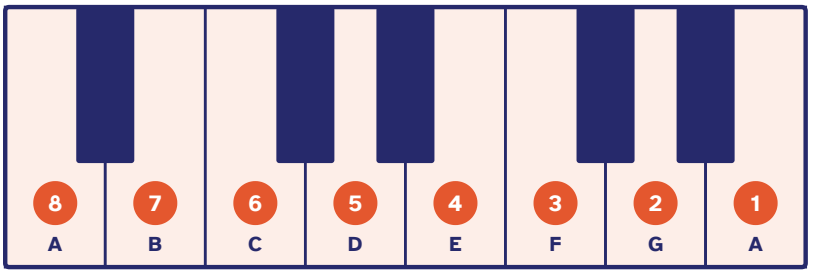
The only two pairs of white keys that touch: E–F and B–C

PART I · PITCH · 1 · CONTINUED

Going down: say it backwards

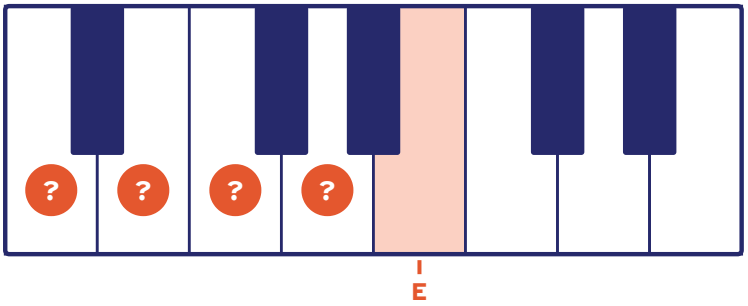
Walking **left**, down the keyboard, the letters run **backwards**: G F E D C B A, then G again. Practise saying them backwards until it is as quick as forwards: reading music that goes down depends on it.

← walk left: A G F E D C B A



EXAMPLE 2

Walk down from E

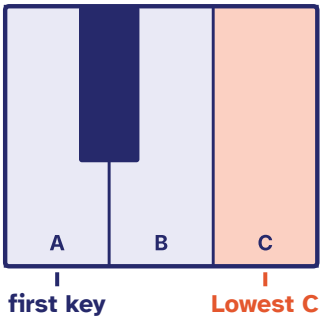


1. **Start on E**, between the two black keys.
2. **Step left** one white key at a time: name each one.
3. **Fill the gaps** out loud too: G _ E _ C.

E **D C B A**: backwards. And G **F** E **D** C.

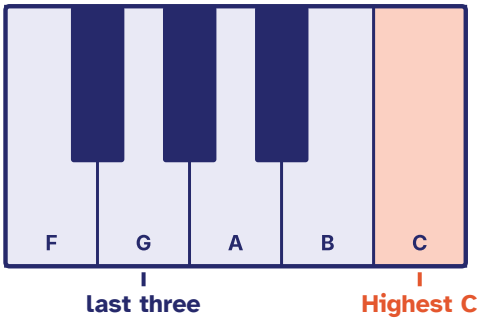
Where the keyboard starts

The very first key, bottom left, is an **A**. Look at the black keys there: only **one**, on its own. It is a group of three that has been cut off: only its end is left. The end of F G A B is **A B**, so the piano starts on A. After A and B comes the first full group of two, and its first key is **Lowest C**.



Where it ends

The very last key, top right, has **no black key** after it. Look left: the last group is **three** black keys, F G A B. After B comes C, the first key of a new group of two that was never built. So the last key is a **C**: **Highest C**.

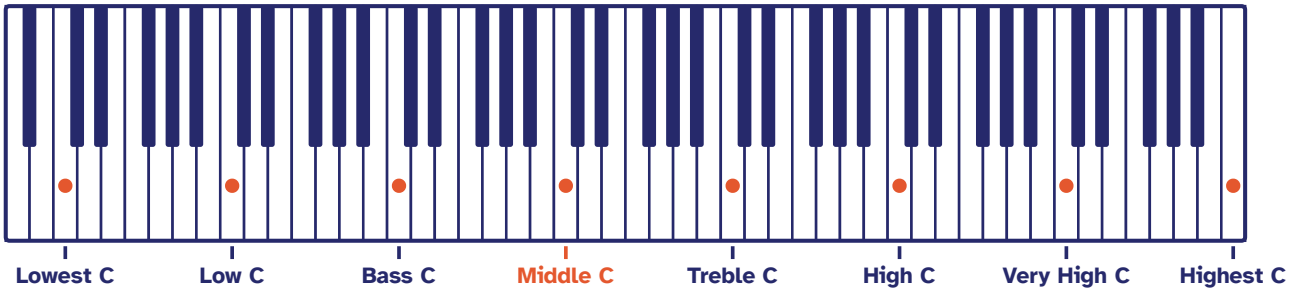


PART I · PITCH · 1 · CONTINUED

The eight Cs have names

Count the Cs from the bottom and there are eight. The C nearest the middle is **Middle C**. Either side are **Bass C** and **Treble C**; further out, **Low C** and **High C**. At the ends: **Lowest C** at the bottom; at the top, **Very High C**, then **Highest C**, the very last key. (No Very Low C: the piano starts on A.) From one C to the next is an **octave**: C D E F G A B C, eight notes, both Cs counted.

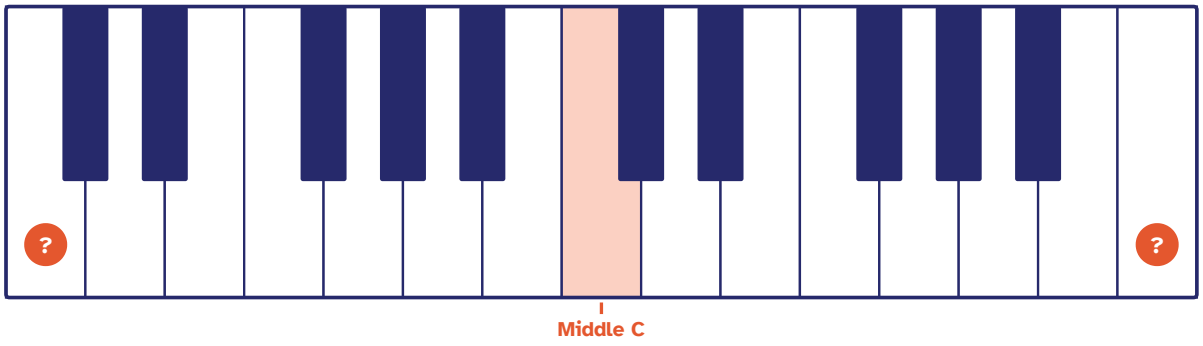
Theory books and apps number them from the bottom instead: C1 is Lowest C, C4 Middle C, C8 Highest C.



All 88 keys, eight Cs: the five in the middle, Low C to High C, are the ones you will use most

EXAMPLE 3

Find Bass C and Treble C



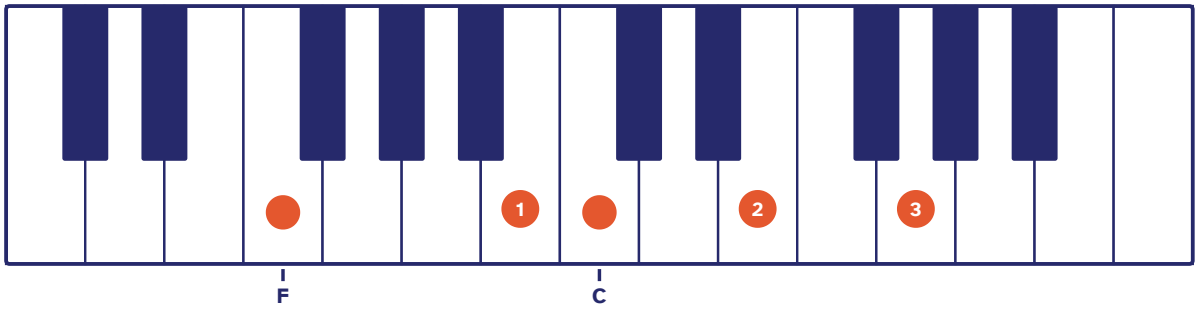
1. **Start on Middle C.**
2. **Walk left** to the next pair of black keys. The C just left of it is one **?**.
3. **Walk right** the same way, to the next pair: the other **?**.

Left **?**: **Bass C**. Right **?**: **Treble C**. Each is one octave, eight notes, from Middle C.

PART I · PITCH · 1 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 4

Find three keys: B, E and G



1 **Which family?** C D E sit round the **two** black keys; F G A B round the **three**.

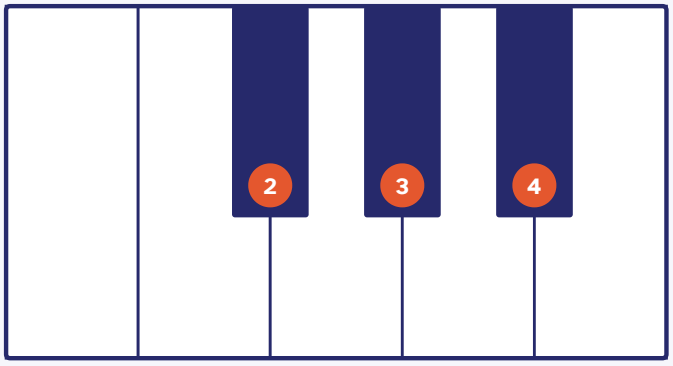
2 **Find its first key:** C or F (the red dots).

3 **Walk on** to each numbered key and name it.

1 is **B**, the last of F G A B · 2 is **E**, the last of C D E · 3 is **G**, one key after F. Find the group, find its first key, walk on: no counting from far away.

YOU KNOW THIS

Hot Cross Buns, on three black keys



Right hand, fingers **2 3 4** on the three black keys (thumb is 1, little finger 5). Play from the top: **4 3 2**, 4 3 2, then quickly, twice as fast, **2 2 2 2, 3 3 3 3**, and 4 3 2 to finish. A whole tune, and not one white key.

Try it. Find another group of three, higher up, and play it again there.

THINK OF IT The black keys are bumps you can feel in the dark. Close your eyes and slide your hand along: two bumps, and the key to their left is C; three bumps, and the key to their left is F.

TRAP

- × Counting every key from C: find the nearest group and start from its C or F.
- × Mixing up the families: C is left of the **two** black keys, F left of the **three**.

SEE ALSO

The staff and the clefs p. 27 · The staff and the keyboard p. 29

PRACTISE IT

Workbook pp. 1–2 · Online: Keyboard Patterns · The Musical Alphabet